



AERO4600 Automatic Flight Control Systems

Assignment 3 — 2024

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Abstract

This Report examines the lateral dynamics and gust response of an aircraft and builds on prior work ?, focusing on utilizing Matlab System Identification Toolbox as well as simulating aircraft response to gust inputs. The primary lateral modes analysed in this report are the side-slip (β) and bank angle (ϕ) of the aircraft, and are evaluated through the influence of aileron/rudder control inputs and gust disturbances. This report also evaluates the impact of sensor noise on the the system identification model and methods of improving the robustness of the system identification process. Additionally, the gust/turbulence was modelled using the Dryden Spectra method to aid in simulating the gust responses, in order to compute the maximum side-slip and bank angle perturbations. These finding contribute to modelling and understanding the aircraft's dynamics and control in the lateral motion.

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1. Introduction

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2. Q1 – Vertical Speed Transfer Function

3. Q2 – Pitch Rate Autopilot

4. Q3 – Vertical Speed Guidance Loop

The vertical speed guidance loop is designed to control the aircraft's ascent and descent rates by incorporating a pitch rate controller as an inner loop. This loop includes a compensator in the forward leg, which processes the vertical speed error to generate a pitch rate command. The pitch rate command then feeds into the inner loop to modulate the elevator input, allowing the system to adjust vertical speed in response to deviations from the desired reference.

4.1. Loop Topology

The complete loop topology of the vertical speed guidance loop is shown in Figure 1. The compensator transforms the vertical speed error ($vs_{ref} - vs$) into a pitch rate command. This command is then processed within the inner loop section ($de2q$), where the transfer functions G_1 and G_2 are used in the pitch rate controller to compute the required elevator deflection (δ_e) to achieve the target pitch rate.

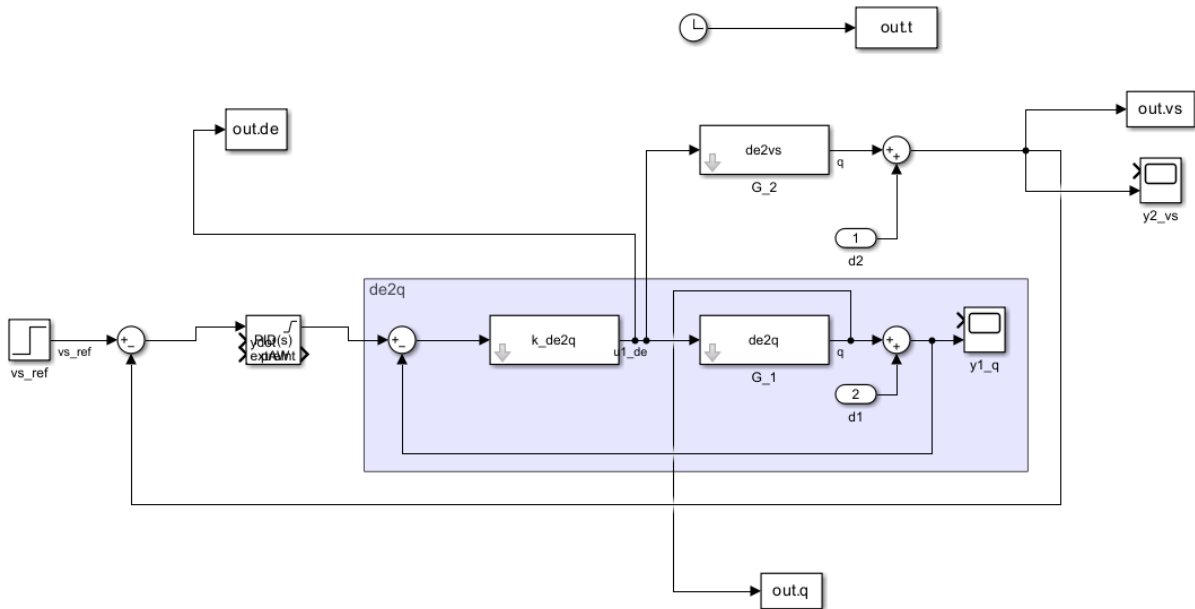


Figure 1: Vertical Speed Guidance Loop Topology

4.2. Aircraft Response to Vertical Speed Command

For a 500 ft/min vertical speed command step input, the vertical speed response is analyzed to verify that it meets the performance criteria.

4.3. Pitch Rate Response

The pitch rate response, following the vertical speed command, is evaluated to confirm that the inner pitch rate control loop accurately tracks the generated pitch rate command.

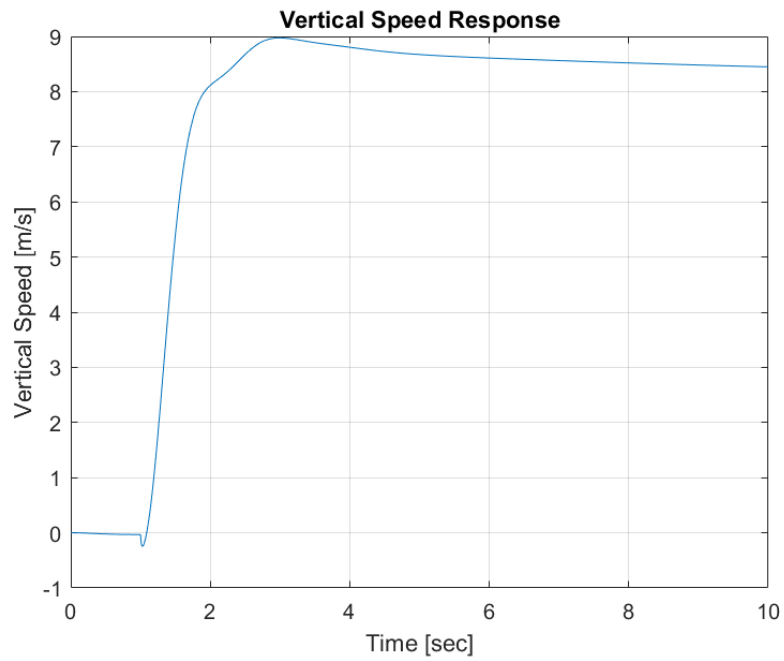


Figure 2: Vertical Speed Response

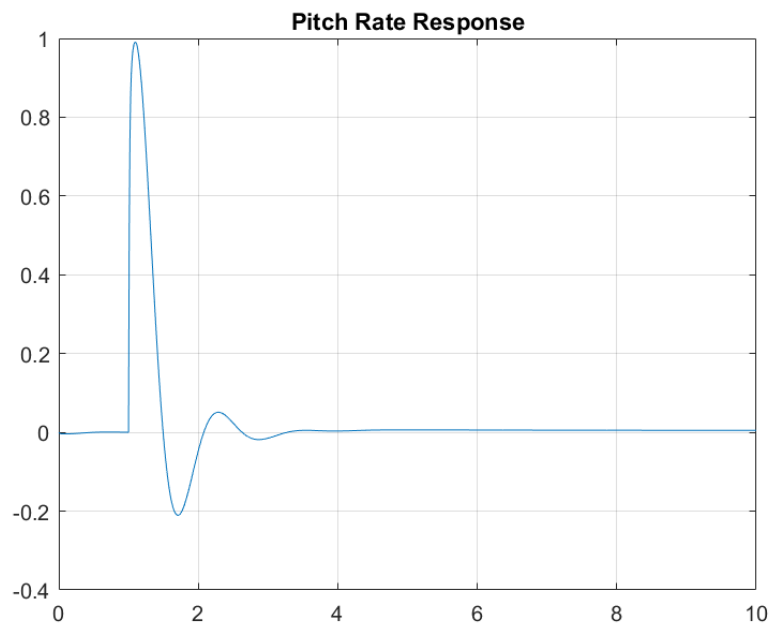


Figure 3: Pitch Rate Response

4.4. Elevator Activity

The elevator control activity is analyzed to ensure that control actions remain within acceptable operational limits.

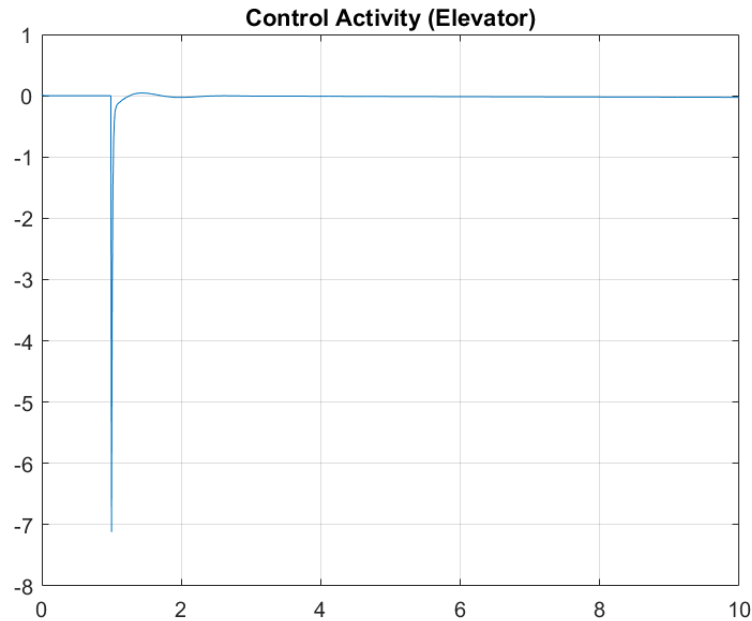


Figure 4: Elevator Control Activity

5. Q4 – Design Auto-Throttle Control System

In this section an auto-throttle design was attempted, wherein errors in airspeed would determine throttle command.

5.1. MIMO Loop Topology

The auto-throttle system was to be achieved with the MIMO loop topology shown in Figure 5.

5.2. Guidance Loop Topology Specifications

This loop was designed to the same specifications as the vertical speed guidance loop, with a vertical speed step input of 500 ft/min. The other constraints could not be implemented however due to difficulties in controlling the system. In addition to the vertical speed input there was also an input for u (airspeed).

5.3. Primary Control Effects

The primary control effects, namely the transfer function of throttle to airspeed ($(dt2u)$), and elevator to vertical speed ($de2vs$), are shown in 6 and 7.

These effects tend to follow a more sinusoidal pattern, reaching similar magnitudes over the simulation period. This is quite different from the responses found from solely the vertical speed control loop (in 4.1). This indicates the the controls have more of an effect on the outputs over time, although because of the increased complexity of the system it is more difficult to tune, and does not reach a stable point (like the outputs of the vertical speed control loop).

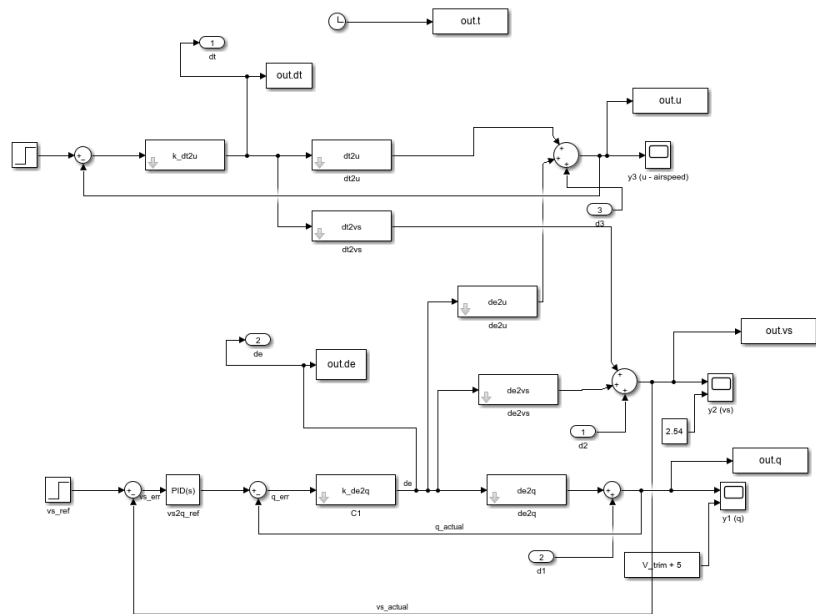


Figure 5: MIMO Simulink Loop for Auto-Throttle Design

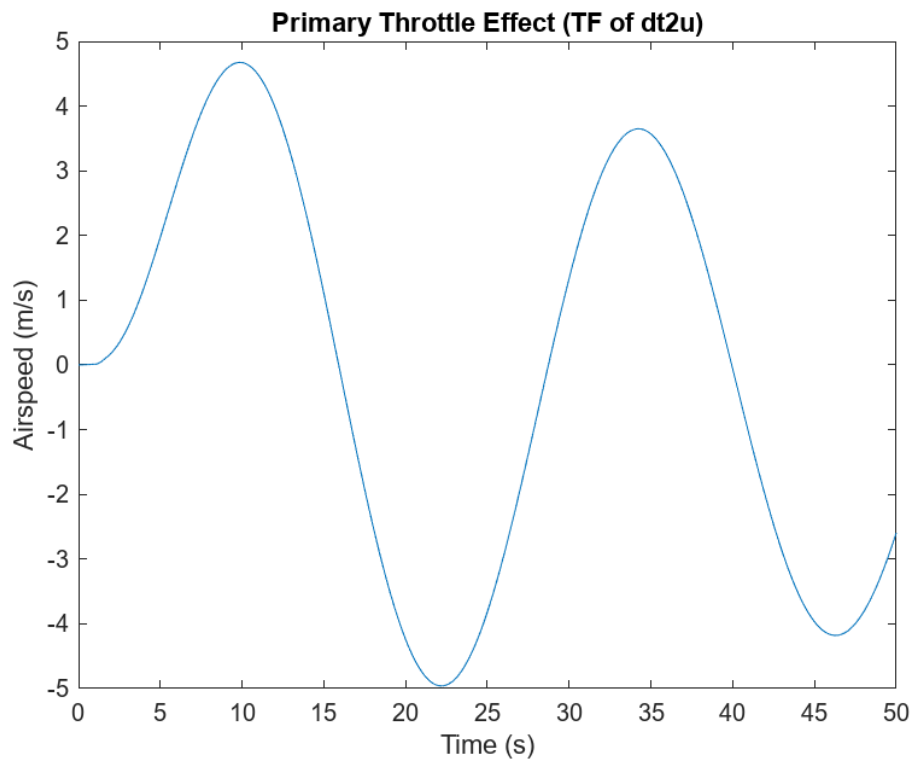


Figure 6: Primary Control Effect: Throttle to Airspeed

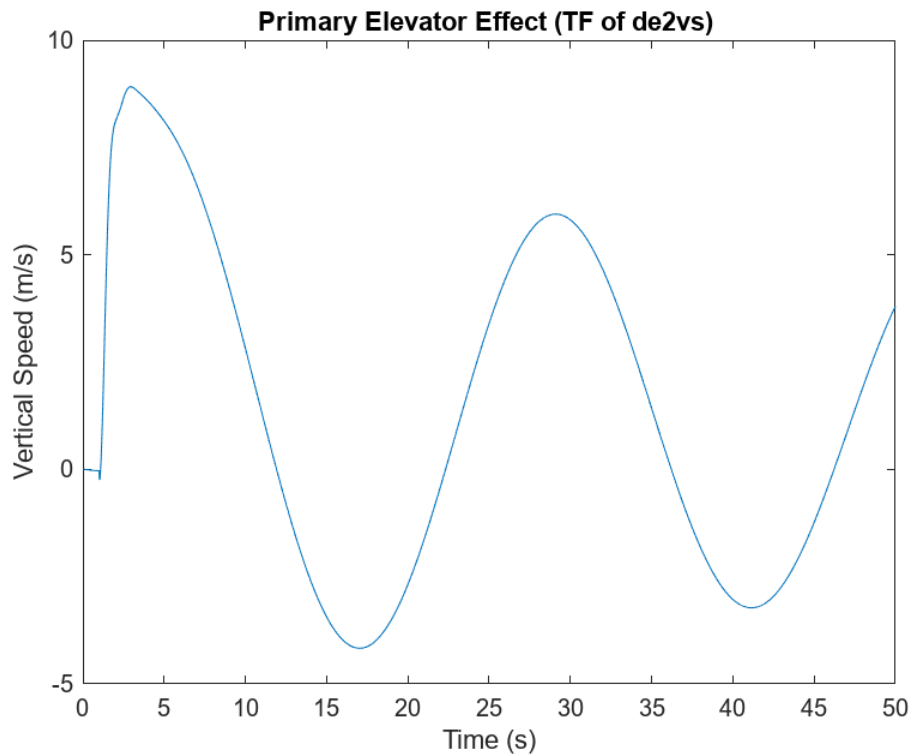


Figure 7: Primary Control Effect: Elevator to Vertical Speed

5.4. Cross-coupling Control Effects

The cross-coupling control effects, namely the transfer function of throttle to vertical speed ($(dt2vs)$), and elevator to airspeed ($de2u$), are shown in ?? and ??.

5.5. Elevator and Throttle Response

5.6. Auto-Throttle Effectiveness

6. Final Design

6.1. Q5 – Implementation of the control and guidance laws

6.2. Q6 – Gust Effectiveness

6.3. Q7 – Commanded Large Vertical Speed

7. Conclusion

References

A. Example of a Table